

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Onboarding Peer Executives

Align on Why Onboarding Matters

- ☐ Acknowledge that onboarding executives is ad hoc and often neglected
- ☐ Commit personally to helping the new executive succeed
- ☐ Align with the CEO (if possible) on shared expectations for the new hire
- ☐ Clarify what success looks like in the first 90 days

Understand the Difference (Executive vs. Engineer Onboarding)

- ☐ Help them understand the **company landscape** (business, team, product, process)
- ☐ Emphasize current *critical issues* and priorities
- ☐ Encourage broad learning before big changes
- ☐ Watch for red flags:
 - ☐ Inaction on key issues
 - ☐ Changing what's already working
 - ☐ Reverting to old-company playbooks prematurely

Share Your Mental Framework (First 2 Weeks Priority)

Data & Reality

- ☐ Show where to find real data (dashboards, board reports, analytics)
- ☐ Encourage validation over narratives

Immediate Focus

- ☐ Clarify the top 2-3 urgent problems
- ☐ Explain current friction areas across teams

Budget & Headcount

- ☐ Discuss norms around budget and hiring requests
- ☐ Explain tradeoffs and historical context

What's Working Well

- ☐ Identify strong processes and high-functioning areas
- ☐ Steer them away from “fixing” what isn’t broken

Honest Team Assessment

- ☐ Provide transparent strengths and gaps on their team
- ☐ Clarify the historical context behind performance issues

Power & Influence Map

- ☐ Introduce long-tenured employees
- ☐ Identify unofficial influencers
- ☐ Clarify implicit power structures

Company Processes

- ☐ Walk through planning cadence (quarterly/annual)
- ☐ Explain the budgeting & headcount process
- ☐ Review performance management systems
- ☐ Outline recurring business reviews

Surprises & Cultural Norms

- ☐ Flag unique company quirks
- ☐ Explain documentation expectations
- ☐ Prepare them for recurring rituals

Define Roles Explicitly

Role Clarity

- ☐ Independently write expectations of each other's roles
- ☐ Compare and discuss differences
- ☐ Resolve accidental misalignments

Handling Conflict

- ☐ Agree on how to manage public disagreement
- ☐ Define when to resolve privately

Escalation Path

- ☐ Explicitly define the escalation process
- ☐ Agree on when/how to involve the CEO
- ☐ Remove ambiguity around decision ownership

Establish Ongoing Partnership Cadence

Relationship Investment

- ☐ Schedule non-transactional time (lunch/dinner)
- ☐ Build personal rapport

Structured 1:1

- ☐ Schedule weekly 60-min structured 1:1
- ☐ Use the shared doc for the agenda
- ☐ Review 2-3 meaningful issues deeply

Joint Forums

- ☐ Identify recurring meetings where your teams intersect
- ☐ Attend key planning/review sessions together

- ☐ Debrief disagreements afterward

Executive Assistant Partnership (If Applicable)

Hiring & Timing

- ☐ Evaluate when an EA is needed
- ☐ Align on the scope of support

Delegation

- ☐ Offload calendar management
- ☐ Delegate communications drafting
- ☐ Delegate recurring meeting coordination
- ☐ Use EA support for offsites & all-hands

Partnership Mindset

- ☐ Treat the EA relationship as a two-way partnership
- ☐ Support their growth and success

Monitor Progress (First 3–6 Months)

- ☐ Observe early signals of effectiveness
- ☐ Provide candid feedback early
- ☐ Reinforce strengths publicly
- ☐ Address missteps before they compound
- ☐ Continue investing even if things feel “fine.”

Guiding Principles

- ☐ Go broad before going deep
- ☐ Make implicit expectations explicit

- ☐ Prevent mistakes rather than recover from them
- ☐ Build trust through repeated, small commitments
- ☐ Remember: mediocre but pleasant executives can linger—early support matters